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OPPOSITION ANALYSIS · PFSA-STYLE INTELLIGENCE REPORT

OPPONENT ANALYSIS

ENGLAND

4-2-3-1 with a double pivot and wide creators

Competition:	FIFA World Cup 2026
Data source:	FIFA Post-Match Summary Reports (Phases of Play)
Report date:	9 October 2026
Classification:	Coaching Staff Only · Confidential



PREPARED BY

TactiVision.ai — Opposition Analysis Unit

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Headline tactical intelligence at a glance

TEAM IDENTITY

- Structured, controlled side balancing possession with wide penetration.
- Patient build-up feeding creative wide players.
- Strong aerial and set-piece presence.

MAIN STRENGTHS

+ Depth of creative quality in wide areas
+ Aerial and set-piece dominance
+ Balanced, controlled build-up

MAIN WEAKNESSES

– Can become predictable and slow in settled possession
– Space between the double pivot on transition
– Occasionally passive without the ball

TACTICAL RISK

Moderate — most vulnerable through central transitions and second balls.

OVERALL RECOMMENDATION

Congest central areas, contest second balls aggressively, and exploit the gaps around the double pivot when they overcommit.

TEAM IDENTITY & TACTICAL PROFILE

Playing identity and headline profile

- Structured, controlled side balancing possession with wide penetration.
- Patient build-up feeding creative wide players.
- Strong aerial and set-piece presence.

ANALYTICAL PROFILE

- Attacking threat — Consistently manufactures strong scoring opportunities; a clear attacking threat.
- Pressing intensity — Applies a balanced, controlled press with selective high engagement.
- Progression / territory — Progresses the ball into high-value zones with dangerous regularity.
- Defensive block — Holds a balanced mid-block, screening central lanes while staying compact.

FORMATION & STRUCTURAL BEHAVIOUR

Shape and positional structure

PREFERRED FORMATION

4-2-3-1 with a double pivot and wide creators

STRUCTURAL BEHAVIOUR

Double pivot provides a stable base; wide players hold width while full-backs support underlaps; defends in two compact banks.

IN-POSSESSION ANALYSIS

Phases of play — with the ball

- Unopposed build-up: the side constructs play from the back unpressured as a defining feature of their game.
- Opposed build-up: the side plays out under pressure at times.
- Progression: the side moves the ball through the thirds in controlled phases regularly.
- Final third: the side sustains attacks in the final third at times.
- Long ball: the side resorts to direct long play only occasionally.
- Attacking transition: the side attacks on the transition at times.
- Counter attack: the side launches outright counter-attacks almost never.
- Set piece: the side generates phases from set plays only occasionally.

OUT-OF-POSSESSION ANALYSIS

Phases of play — without the ball

- High press: the side presses high up the pitch only occasionally.
- Mid press: the side engages the press in midfield only occasionally.
- Low press: the side presses from a deep starting point almost never.
- High block: the side defends from a high block only occasionally.
- Mid block: the side defends from a mid-block regularly.
- Low block: the side drops into a low block at times.
- Recovery: the side is recovering shape after being stretched only occasionally.
- Defensive transition: the side is exposed in defensive transition at times.
- Counter-press: the side counter-presses on loss of the ball at times.

TRANSITIONS

Attacking & defensive transition behaviour

ATTACKING TRANSITION

Transitions with intent through wide outlets but generally prioritises retaining structure over reckless commitment.

DEFENSIVE TRANSITION

Recovers into a mid-block promptly; can show gaps around the pivot before the block re-forms.

SET-PIECE PROFILE

Dead-ball tendencies

A major set-piece threat — well-drilled routines and dominant aerial targets at both ends.

KEY PLAYERS & THREAT MATRIX

Individuals to neutralise

Player	Role	Strength	Weakness	Instruction
Jude Bellingham	Advanced 8 / arriving threat	Late runs into the box	Vacates midfield on the break	Track his forward runs man-to-man from deep.
Declan Rice	Deep pivot	Ball-winning and progression	Exposed when partner steps out	Overload the pivot line to create a spare man.
Bukayo Saka	Right winger	Cut-ins and cutbacks	Leaves the right channel open	Attack the space behind him with early runs.

STRENGTHS & WEAKNESSES

Consolidated SWOT assessment

STRENGTHS

+ Depth of creative quality in wide areas
+ Aerial and set-piece dominance
+ Balanced, controlled build-up

WEAKNESSES

– Can become predictable and slow in settled possession
– Space between the double pivot on transition
– Occasionally passive without the ball

MATCH PLAN RECOMMENDATIONS

How to exploit and how to contain

IN POSSESSION — HOW TO EXPLOIT

- Progress through central overloads to exploit space around the pivot.
- Attack the channel behind their advancing full-backs.

OUT OF POSSESSION — HOW TO DEFEND

- Stay compact centrally and force play wide.
- Defend set-pieces with disciplined marking of aerial targets.

PRESSING TRIGGERS

- Backward and lateral passes in their build-up phase.

RISK ZONES & VULNERABILITIES

Where we are most likely to be hurt

DANGER ZONES

- ! Wide cutbacks from the by-line.
- ! Second balls around set-pieces.

OUR RISK ZONES

- ! Aerial situations and set-piece deliveries.
- ! Late arrivals into the box from midfield.

PRE-MATCH TACTICAL PLAN

Phased game-management script

0–15 MINUTES — ESTABLISH CONTROL

Match their structure and contest the first set-pieces decisively.

MID-GAME — BUILD & DEFEND

Break their rhythm by pressing the pivot and denying wide service.

70+ MINUTES — GAME MANAGEMENT

Stay alert to aerial substitutes and set-piece variations.

POST-MATCH ANALYTICAL REVIEW

Review framework for after the fixture

Review set-piece defending and how well central areas were protected against arriving runners.